

Q+A

FOR A GOOD CAUSE

As she gears up for the release of her new film Badhaai Do, *actor* ***Bhumi Pednekar*** *seems intent on breaking yet more social taboos with her cinema*

Q. In *Badhaai Do*, your character is a lesbian in a marriage of convenience with a gay policeman (Rajkummar Rao). What can we expect?

The beauty of the film is that it makes you laugh, but not at the cost of the two characters. It looks at same-sex relationship from a humane perspective. Sumi [her character] is like anyone—she seeks love and freedom. She's a coward at times, but then very brave at other times.

Q. *Toilet: Ek Prem Katha*, *Saand ki Aankh*, *Sonchiriya*, *Bala*...you lean towards films that touch on social issues. Do you think films can change people's mindsets?

I really hope so. Cinema needs to have a larger meaning. The idea of *Badhaai Do* is that we and our families accept us for who we are. That is easier said than done. It does force you to think about your choices and opinions.

Q. *Badhaai Do* is being called a "spiritual sequel" to *Badhaai Ho*, which was a hit family entertainer. How alike are they?

The franchise stands for breaking taboos. There's a certain amount of conditioning that we have had through generations that makes us think in only one way. There are so many biases and that's what the franchise seeks to change.

Q. You have carved a niche for playing women with a cause. In 2022, you seem to be mixing it up with a few mainstream films like *Raksha Bandhan* and *Govinda Naam Mera*.

I try to keep a balance. I play characters I love; it could be five scenes or a film based completely around me. I don't see how commercial it is and I don't believe in formula. My ethos is always to play strongly-etched parts. I want a legacy.

—with Suhani Singh